

2025 TKEthics Invitational Fall Tournament

CASES PACKAGE

Welcome to the cases for [2025 TKEthics Invitational Fall Tournament](#), an event held in partnership with the [Modus Ponens Institute](#). This global competition encourages students to engage in thoughtful discussions on justice, fairness, and real-world ethical dilemmas. Unlike traditional debates, where opposing views are assigned, the TKEthics Invitational allows students to defend the positions they genuinely believe are correct. Success is determined by the depth, perceptiveness, and rigor of their arguments. This event fosters the development of ethical awareness, critical thinking, civil discourse, and an appreciation for diverse viewpoints. Participation in the TKEthics Invitionals also enhances civic engagement and ethical reasoning skills.

Case Overview

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CASE 1: FTX's Charitable Donations

Ethics Cup case set 2024

In November 2022, FTX, one of the world's largest cryptocurrency exchanges, collapsed and filed for bankruptcy. In the aftermath, it transpired that customer deposits had been used by Alameda—an associated hedge fund—to make risky trades that had not paid off. When customers attempted to withdraw their money, FTX didn't have it.

More failures of corporate control were discovered during the bankruptcy proceedings, and several FTX executives have been charged with fraud. At least a billion dollars of investors' assets is apparently still missing.

FTX founder and CEO Sam Bankman-Fried was a proponent of effective altruism—the movement that aims to use “evidence and reason to figure out how to benefit others as much as possible, and [take] action on that basis.” The FTX Foundation donated more than \$100 million to effective altruist organizations in 2022, including to grant-making organizations that themselves distributed the funds to individuals and groups they judged were doing good.

FTX's collapse has led to much soul-searching among effective altruists. But among some recipients of FTX support, it prompted a more immediate ethical question. FTX announced a process for voluntarily returning funds to the FTX estate. Should FTX grantees make efforts to return some or all of the funds they received? After all, it appeared that these funds resulted from defrauding innocent people who thought that their cryptocurrency holdings were safely deposited at FTX.

In defense of not voluntarily returning funds, it might be argued that effective altruist organizations are already using the money to do the most good in the world. If the money would go towards saving children from dying of malaria, then that is more important than trying to return it to someone who had spare cash to invest in crypto.

Alternatively, it might be argued that if the money is already spent, there is no case for getting it back: just as a plumber working on an FTX building would not have to return their wages, so a charity working to help others does not have to return spent donations.

On the other hand, it might be argued that the FTX funds came from fraud and so constitute stolen goods. Stolen goods should be returned to their owners. More pragmatically, an effective altruist might think that more good would be done in the long run if people in the movement were seen as honest.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. If someone was paid using stolen money, do they have an obligation to return the money to the victim?
2. Does it make a difference if the recipient had no idea that the money might be stolen?
3. Should the recipients of unspent funds from FTX try to return the money?

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[3] <https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/ftx-debtors-announce-process-for-voluntary-return-of-avoidable-payments-301706546.html>

[4] <https://forum.effectivealtruism.org/posts/CcNaQmrtdeC9PPixK/under-what-conditions-should-ftx-grantees-voluntarily-return>

CASE 2: Orphan Drugs

Ethics Cup case set 2024

An orphan drug is any drug that treats a very serious condition where the condition is so rare, and the cost of developing the drug so high, that it is unlikely a drug company would ever recuperate the development costs involved in researching and developing it.

Given that public funds are limited, there is a straightforward rationale for public health services to treat orphan drugs as a non-priority. If they're expensive and benefit very few people, why worry about them never getting produced? Certainly, utilitarianism—the ethical theory that instructs us to produce as much good as possible—would argue against spending any public funds on orphan drugs. However, the National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE), which determines which drugs are provided for free on the English NHS, rejects this strict utilitarian reasoning. NICE states that “a simple utilitarian approach...is unlikely to produce guidance which would recognise the particular circumstances of” orphan drugs.

Typically, NICE bases its decisions on how many additional years of good life—Quality-Adjusted Life Years, or QALYs—a drug is expected to provide, and at what monetary cost. Drugs generally must offer QALYs at less than £20,000–£30,000 per year to be approved. This is essentially a utilitarian cost-benefit standard. However, for orphan drugs, NICE is willing to approve drugs that cost over £100,000 per QALY.

Sally suffers from severe depression. Her symptoms include lack of motivation, sleep deprivation, sadness, loneliness, and loss of appetite. These symptoms are debilitating—she cannot go out, maintain relationships, or keep a job. After years of trying various antidepressants and therapy with little success, her psychiatrist is recommending a last-resort option: a drug called orphanillin, which is an orphan drug.

NICE is currently evaluating whether orphanillin should be approved for NHS coverage. Sally cannot afford it on her own, so she is desperate for NICE to approve it. However, the cost is £100,000 per QALY.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is the case for utilitarian reasoning being abandoned in the case of NICE and orphan drugs any stronger or weaker than the case for utilitarian reasoning being abandoned more generally by agencies whose job it is to distribute public funds?
2. Does Sally's desire for orphanillin to be approved—a decision that would lead to the population served by the English NHS being less healthy overall—show a flaw in her character?
3. If NICE had no special policy for orphan drugs, would this be unfair to people who have rare conditions and are thus systematically disadvantaged compared to those with common conditions?
4. Should NICE approve orphanillin?

SOURCES

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CASE 3: AI Detection Software in Education

Ethics Cup case set 2024

Following the recent development of large language models such as ChatGPT, several anti-plagiarism software systems have introduced artificial intelligence (AI) detection tools. These tools go beyond identifying copied text from known sources; they now estimate how much of a submission was generated by AI.

Many schools and universities worldwide have considered adopting these tools to detect when assignments are produced by AI rather than by students. The goal is to uphold academic integrity and enforce institutional rules.

Adopting AI detection tools can help deter students from relying too heavily on AI to write essays, final exams, or dissertations. Knowing that work will be screened for AI use may discourage dishonesty. In this way, such tools aim to promote fairness and ensure that students complete the academic tasks expected of them.

However, these detection systems have significant limitations. First, they lack transparency. They provide a result—such as “80% AI-generated”—but offer no detailed evidence or reasoning behind that judgment.

Second, they are not perfectly accurate. These tools sometimes produce false positives, falsely identifying human-written work as AI-generated. For example, Turnitin, a leading plagiarism detection platform, reports that their AI detector may incorrectly flag 1 in every 100 fully human-written documents. In a class of 200 students, this could mean two students are wrongly accused of misconduct.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Due to the lack of transparency of AI detection tools, teachers may find themselves in the position of punishing students without being able to provide additional evidence beyond the software’s verdict. Is it wrong for a teacher to penalize a student for plagiarism without further proof?
2. The risk of false positives is not unique to AI detection. Legal systems also risk unjust convictions. In the case of AI-detection tools, is that risk outweighed by the overall benefits?
3. Should universities and colleges adopt AI detection tools?

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CASE 4: AI law firms

Maya runs a tiny startup. Late on Friday, a big customer sends a long contract and wants it back by Monday. Her usual lawyer needs two weeks. Instead, Maya tries a new “AI-enabled” law firm that keeps licensed lawyers in the loop but lets AI do the repetitive parts. By Saturday morning she has a marked-up contract and a plain-English summary for a flat fee she can afford. For people like Maya—and for low-income clients who often get no help at all—this sounds like a breakthrough. In the U.S., a national study found 92% of serious civil legal problems faced by low-income Americans get no or not enough legal help [1].

Crosby is one example getting attention as an actual law firm that uses lawyer-supervised AI to speed up things like contract review, aiming to deliver quality work faster and cheaper than traditional methods [2]. Some regulators are tentatively positive, too: Utah’s court-run “sandbox,” which audits experimental legal service models, reported no evidence of material or substantial consumer harm in the files it reviewed, while keeping close oversight in place [3]. The hope is simple: if AI helps lawyers handle routine work quickly—and the lawyers still check everything—more people can get timely, affordable help.

But speed isn’t the only value that matters. Lawyers still owe clients core duties: know what you’re doing, protect private information, communicate clearly, and supervise any tech or helpers. In 2024 the American Bar Association reminded lawyers that if they use generative AI, they must verify its output, explain its limits to clients, and keep client data safe [4]. Courts have already punished attorneys who filed briefs with fake, AI-invented cases—Mata v. Avianca is the famous example—showing that judgment and honesty can’t be automated away [5]. And regulators now police marketing promises: in 2025 the U.S. Federal Trade Commission banned DoNotPay from making deceptive “AI lawyer” claims and required monetary relief and notices to customers [6]. These actions point to the ethical stakes: access and fairness vs accuracy, truthfulness, privacy, and accountability. If firms overpromise, skip human review to scale faster, or hide how they use client data, the very people these tools aim to help could be harmed.

Back to Maya. In one version, the lawyer-plus-AI team flags a risky indemnity and a quiet data-sharing clause; she signs stronger terms and her company grows. In another, the system “hallucinates” a precedent, misses a local rule, and gives her a false sense of security; a dispute later exposes the gap between looking thorough and being careful, and Maya pays the price. These different outcomes raise questions about how society should approach AI legal aid. Should courts and bar regulators open the door wider to AI law firms because they expand access, or move slowly until standards, audits, and remedies are stronger? What sort of regulations might be warranted, and who should be responsible when something important slips through?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. If AI makes routine legal work faster and cheaper, what minimum safeguards should be required before these services go public?
2. When AI shrinks tasks from hours to minutes, how should fees change to stay fair to clients?
3. Where is the boundary between legal information and the practice of law in AI tools, and who should enforce it?
4. Which values should carry the most weight here—access and cost or safety and professional integrity—and why?

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[2] TechCrunch (Jun 17, 2025), “Sequoia-backed Crosby launches a new kind of AI-powered law firm.” [TechCrunch](#)

[3] Utah Office of Legal Services Innovation, Activity Report: January 2024 (audits found no evidence of material or substantial harm). [utahinnovationoffice.org](#)

[4] American Bar Association, Formal Opinion 512 (2024): duties when using generative AI (verify output, protect confidentiality, communicate, supervise). [American Bar Association](#)

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[6] U.S. Federal Trade Commission (Feb 11, 2025): Final order against DoNotPay prohibiting deceptive “AI lawyer” claims and requiring monetary relief and notices. [Federal Trade Commission](#)

CASE 5: Mars Colonization

Since the dawn of human space travel, interplanetary colonization has become an ever more realistic goal. Companies like Space X, and government organizations including NASA, have entire pages on their websites dedicated to the idea of settling humans on nearby planets– most often Mars.

Mars is considered the most reasonable option for a number of reasons. First, a round trip flight using current technology would take around 2.7 years, including 300 days of loitering time in the Martian vicinity while awaiting the planetary alignment necessary for a trip home. Second, the length of the day is remarkably similar to that of Earth, at 24 hours and 47 minutes. Third, while the atmosphere is mostly CO₂, Space X thinks we can use that to grow plants as long as we find a way to compress the molecules in the right way.

Elon Musk has long touted the need to escape earth in order to allow humanity to survive into the distant future. He is concerned about a number of potential threats to human survival on earth, including the risk of a third world war. He said, “If there’s a third world war we want to make sure there’s enough of a seed of human civilization somewhere else to bring it back and shorten the length of the dark ages”. Whether we bring about the demise of the earth or not, our Sun is set to expand and devour the earth in a few billion years, giving the survival of the Earth a limited timeline whether we solve our earthly concerns or not.

However, critics, including the Youtuber Sabine Hossenfelder, point out that Musk’s Mars plan ignores urgent problems on Earth, and might create a moral hazard, where we allow issues like global warming to get worse because we think we can leave the earth when it becomes uninhabitable. Other criticism includes the idea that the project is economically unrealistic, with no clear return on investment and a scale so vast it would need massive government backing to even begin (which could be used for solving problems closer to home, like homelessness, climate change, or unemployment). Skeptics also stress that Mars is brutally inhospitable, so colonists would be trapped in fragile habitats with constant risk of failure and death.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is humanity morally obligated to prioritize survival in the very long term (colonizing Mars) over solving urgent crises on Earth (climate change, poverty, conflict)?
2. If people volunteer to colonize Mars, do governments or private companies owe them the same protections and rights as Earth citizens?
3. Should Mars settlements be governed by global cooperation rather than national or corporate ownership?

SOURCES

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- [2] <https://www.spacex.com/humanspaceflight/mars/>
- [3] <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2018/mar/11/elon-musk-colonise-mars-third-world-war>
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CASE 6 No platforming

Ethics Cup case set 2026

Mainstream and social media is rife with bias, propaganda, and misinformation, much of which is harmful. For example, false reports concerning the effectiveness and safety of vaccinations can lead to outbreaks of previously eradicated viruses. Given the seeming bona fide sources of such claims, it can be difficult for many to determine their veracity. It would thus seem important to discredit and perhaps even prohibit the spread of clear and harmful misinformation. One way to do this would be no-platforming: where a person or group is prevented from contributing to a public debate, either through policy or protest, on the grounds that their beliefs are dangerous or unacceptable. Examples of this include people having their social media accounts deactivated and speakers not being invited (or uninvited) to take part in public presentation or debate of their views.

The controlling of free speech is a problematic endeavour, however. Many liberal theorists, such as John Stuart Mill, have argued that the free exchange of ideas is not only a right but an important feature of democratic society. Mill goes as far to say that even false and offensive ideas should be allowed to be presented in public, since without a free and open debate between competing ideas we risk dogmatism and intellectual stagnation. He adds that a free marketplace of ideas is important for the challenging of received opinions and the intellectual progress of the community. Suppression of free speech, on this view, is thus a harm to the individuals whose freedom is restricted and to society as a whole.

Proponents of no-platforming argue that there are some ideas which are so clearly false and harmful that their dissemination ought to be prohibited. They argue that when the scientific community has conclusively concluded that particular vaccinations are safe, that anthropogenic climate change is occurring, that there is no evidence of genetic difference in intelligence between racialised groups, etc., it is inappropriate and dangerous to allow people to present false and misleading reports to the contrary. They maintain, in particular, that esteemed public institutions such as universities have a right and duty to not provide a platform to speakers who are known to spread falsehoods and that they should not be expected to provide a both-sides representation of every possible debate. Their claim, in other words, is that public institutions ought to deny a platform to certain speakers—a claim that is compatible with the view that private companies have the right to choose what ideas they platform and with whom they associate.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is there a morally significant difference between private companies and public institutions when it comes to no-platforming?
2. Is no-platforming permissible?
3. (For those that answered 'yes' to Question 2.) Is it appropriate to platform a controversial speaker on a topic other than those on which they hold controversial views? Examples include inviting J.K. Rowling to an event on fantasy fiction or Peter Singer to an event on charitable giving.⁷
4. (For those that answered 'no' to Question 2.) How should we deal with hate speech?

CASE 7: AI friendship

Many people today say they feel lonely. In 2023, the U.S. Surgeon General called loneliness and isolation a public-health crisis, noting sharp declines in in-person time with friends—from roughly 60 minutes/day in 2003 to 20 minutes/day in 2020 [1]. More recent time-use data suggest Americans spent only about 26 minutes/day with friends in 2023 [2]. Surveys also show people reporting fewer close friends than in past decades [3]. Loneliness isn't just unpleasant, it's also linked to worse mental and physical health outcomes [1].

One possible tool to solve the “loneliness epidemic” is AI companionship; friendly chatbots and social robots designed to listen, encourage, and check in. Early evidence is mixed but promising in some settings. A 2025 study of a social chatbot found reductions in loneliness among new users over four weeks [4]. A 2024 meta-analysis reported that social robot programs were associated with decreases in loneliness and depression (though results varied by study) [5]. A 2025 systematic review focused on older adults reached a similar, cautious conclusion: AI interventions can help reduce loneliness for some, while methods and durability of effects remain uneven [6]. Meanwhile, real-world adoption is large and growing—Character.AI reports ~20 million monthly users, many of them teens and young adults [7].

But there are serious risks. Large chatbots can be over-agreeable, optimizing for user satisfaction rather than challenge or protection. Safety testing in 2025 found chatbots inconsistent on suicide-related prompts: better with obvious emergencies, worse in gray areas where a human friend might notice warning signs and act [8][9]. News reporting has linked prolonged chatbot interactions to tragic outcomes, including a recent New York Times report about a man who died by suicide after obtaining harmful “fiction” instructions from ChatGPT [10]. Youth safety is an ongoing concern: an investigation found fake-celebrity bots on Character.AI sending sexual and self-harm messages to 13–15-year-olds [11]. There is a worry that outsourcing friendship to AI could crowd out real human friendship, replacing real relationships with imitations that don't actually have our best interests in mind.

But there is also a deeper concern about what happens if AI becomes as good as human friends. What does a world look like in which the majority of our social requirements are satisfied not by humans, but by bots? Sherry Turkle warns sociable tech can offer an “illusion of companionship without the demands of friendship.” [12] Robert Nozick's “experience machine” asks whether we should choose a pleasant simulation over reality [13]. Is there something about friendship that would be lost if our friends weren't actually “real” but merely simulated?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. If an AI companion reduces a person's loneliness today, is that by itself a strong ethical reason to encourage AI friendship? Why or why not?
2. What minimum safety rules (if any) should be required for chatbots marketed as “companions,” especially for teens? Be specific.
3. Would replacing many human friendships with AI harm communities even if most users feel happier? How would you measure that?

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CASE 8: Rhinoplasty and Ethnic Heritage

Ethics Cup case set 2026

Chiara is a 28-year-old Italian woman who moved to the United Kingdom for work. From a young age, Chiara was teased for her prominent Italian nose. She had been called various names like “beaky,” “hooked,” and “witchy” by her classmates. This treatment and reaction to her nose led her to develop a severe insecurity about the feature through her teenage years and into adult life. On the other hand, her family celebrates the feature as a mark of beauty and heritage, as it is common not only in the family but a lot of Italians. Despite this, Chiara has always had negative associations of shame and ridicule with her nose.

She has recently booked a rhinoplasty consultation, in the hope that the procedure will bring a sense of relief from her insecurity and a renewed sense of confidence. However, as the appointment approaches, Chiara begins to feel morally conflicted. The surgery itself is relatively minor, but it would permanently alter a physical feature that connects her to her family and her Italian identity. Chiara worries that seeking a more “conventionally attractive” nose amounts to conforming to Anglo-American beauty standards and rejecting her heritage. This seems to be constantly amplified by social media and the normalcy of undergoing surgical procedures. She wonders whether she would still be “herself” after the surgery and has doubts about whether it will renew her confidence as she hopes it will.

It can be argued that Chiara is right to feel conflicted. On this view, changing her nose is not merely a cosmetic alteration but a rejection of her ancestry. To undergo a serious surgical procedure just to conform to societal beauty standards suggests that Chiara has internalised the prejudice she experienced, and that she sees her Italian features as something to be fixed. Furthermore, some would claim that Chiara has a duty to resist the beauty norms to which she feels pressure to conform, not only for herself and her family but for others who share her heritage.

However, others may argue that Chiara has no such duty. Instead, she should do what is best for her wellbeing. If the teasing has given her problems with her body image and confidence, then cosmetic surgery may be the only form of self-care left. On this view, Chiara is not rejecting her culture but exercising autonomy over her body. Some people wear makeup or style their hair to boost their confidence, and surgery is simply another way to alter one’s appearance.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Does it count strongly against Chiara getting the rhinoplasty that she would be reinforcing harmful beauty standards by doing so?
2. Can a procedure as serious and permanent as rhinoplasty ever be a form of self-care?
3. If we criticise Chiara for having a rhinoplasty to make herself feel better about her appearance then are we then committed, as a matter of consistency, to criticising those who wear makeup, high heels, fake tans, etc. to make themselves feel better about their appearance?